

AUTOMATION GUIDE

n8n Automation Starter Pack

Everything you need to start automating your business with n8n — from setup to your first 10 workflows.

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What Is n8n?

n8n is an open-source workflow automation tool that lets you connect apps and automate tasks without writing code. Think of it as a more powerful, free alternative to Zapier — but with the ability to run it on your own server, connect to any API, and build far more complex workflows.

In 2026, n8n has become the go-to automation tool for developers, content creators, and small business owners who want serious automation power without the serious price tag. The self-hosted version is completely free. Forever.

■ Pro Tip

n8n has over 400 built-in integrations including all major AI APIs (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google AI), social media platforms, email services, databases, and more. If it has an API, n8n can connect to it.

Getting Started with n8n

Option 1: n8n Cloud (Easiest)

Go to n8n.io and sign up for a cloud account. You get a free trial, then pay from \$20/month. No technical setup required. Best for beginners who want to start immediately.

Option 2: Railway.app (Free)

Create an account at railway.app. Search for "n8n" in the template marketplace. Click deploy. You will have n8n running in under 5 minutes at no cost. Best for people who want free hosting with minimal setup.

Option 3: Self-Hosted (Advanced)

Install Docker on your server, then run: `docker run -it --rm --name n8n -p 5678:5678 n8nio/n8n`. Access n8n at <http://localhost:5678>. Best for full control and privacy.

Understanding n8n: Key Concepts

Workflows

A workflow is a series of connected steps that run automatically. Each step is a "node." Nodes can trigger actions, process data, or connect to external services.

Nodes

Nodes are the building blocks of n8n workflows. There are trigger nodes (which start the workflow), action nodes (which do things), and logic nodes (which make decisions). n8n has 400+ built-in nodes.

Triggers

Every workflow starts with a trigger. Common triggers include: a webhook receiving data, a schedule (run every hour), a new email arriving, a form being submitted, or a new row being added to a spreadsheet.

Credentials

To connect n8n to external services, you add credentials (API keys, passwords). These are stored securely and reused across workflows. You only need to set them up once.

Expressions

Expressions let you use data from previous steps in your workflow. For example, `{{ $json.email }}` pulls the email field from the previous node's output. This is how data flows through your workflows.

10 Workflows to Build First

These are the most useful n8n workflows for content creators and small business owners. Build them in this order — each one teaches you a new concept.

1. New Blog Post to Twitter Thread

Difficulty: Beginner

- Trigger: RSS Feed node watching your blog's RSS feed
 - Node 2: HTTP Request to fetch the full post content
 - Node 3: OpenAI node — send the content with prompt "Turn this blog post into a 5-tweet Twitter thread"
 - Node 4: Twitter node — post the thread
 - Result: Every new blog post automatically becomes a Twitter thread
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2. Email to Task Manager

Difficulty: Beginner

- Trigger: Gmail node — triggers when email arrives with label "action-required"
 - Node 2: OpenAI node — extract the task, deadline, and priority from the email
 - Node 3: Notion node (or Todoist/Asana) — create a new task with the extracted information
 - Result: Important emails automatically become tasks without any manual work
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3. Daily News Briefing

Difficulty: Beginner

- Trigger: Schedule node — runs every morning at 7am
 - Node 2: RSS Feed nodes (multiple) — pull from 5-10 news sources in your niche
 - Node 3: OpenAI node — summarize the top stories and extract the 5 most relevant items
 - Node 4: Gmail node — send the summary to your email
 - Result: A personalized AI-curated news briefing delivered to your inbox daily
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4. Content Repurposing Machine

Difficulty: Intermediate

- Trigger: Webhook — receives the text of a new blog post from your CMS
 - Node 2: OpenAI — rewrite for LinkedIn (professional tone, key insights)
 - Node 3: OpenAI — rewrite for Twitter (thread format, hook-focused)
 - Node 4: OpenAI — rewrite for Instagram (visual-focused, emoji, hashtags)
 - Node 5: LinkedIn, Twitter, Instagram nodes — post to each platform
 - Result: One blog post automatically becomes content for 3 platforms
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5. Lead Notification System

Difficulty: Intermediate

- Trigger: Webhook — receives form submission data from your website
 - Node 2: Supabase/Google Sheets — save lead data to your database
 - Node 3: OpenAI — analyze the lead and score it (High/Medium/Low)
 - Node 4: IF node — if High priority, send Slack message; if Medium/Low, send email
 - Node 5: Gmail — send a personalized follow-up email to the lead
 - Result: Leads are automatically scored, saved, and followed up with
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6. YouTube to Blog Post

Difficulty: Intermediate

- Trigger: HTTP Request — fetches new videos from a YouTube channel RSS feed
 - Node 2: HTTP Request — gets the YouTube video transcript via a transcript API
 - Node 3: OpenAI — converts the transcript into a well-structured blog post
 - Node 4: WordPress/Ghost node — creates a draft post in your CMS
 - Result: Any YouTube video becomes a draft blog post automatically
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7. Price Monitoring Alert

Difficulty: Intermediate

- Trigger: Schedule node — runs every 6 hours
- Node 2: HTTP Request — scrapes the price from a product page
- Node 3: IF node — checks if price is below your target threshold
- Node 4 (if yes): Gmail/Slack — sends you an alert with the current price and link
- Result: You get notified the moment a product drops below your target price

8. Customer Support Triage

Difficulty: Advanced

- Trigger: Gmail — new email to support@yourdomain.com
 - Node 2: OpenAI — classify the email (billing, technical, general, urgent)
 - Node 3: OpenAI — draft a response based on your FAQ document
 - Node 4: IF node — if urgent, create a Slack alert; otherwise send draft response for review
 - Node 5: Gmail — send the draft or alert based on classification
 - Result: Support emails are classified, drafted, and routed without manual reading
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9. Social Media Monitor

Difficulty: Advanced

- Trigger: Schedule node — runs every hour
 - Node 2: Twitter/Reddit API — searches for mentions of your brand or keywords
 - Node 3: OpenAI — analyzes sentiment (positive, negative, neutral) and importance
 - Node 4: IF node — if negative or important, create immediate alert
 - Node 5: Airtable — log all mentions with sentiment scores
 - Result: You always know when people are talking about your brand or topic
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10. Automated Report Generator

Difficulty: Advanced

- Trigger: Schedule node — runs every Monday at 9am
 - Node 2: Multiple data sources — Google Analytics, Stripe, Supabase
 - Node 3: Code node — aggregates and formats all the data
 - Node 4: OpenAI — writes a narrative summary of the week's performance
 - Node 5: Gmail — sends the full report to you and your team
 - Result: A comprehensive weekly business report generated and delivered automatically
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Common n8n Mistakes to Avoid

■ Not handling errors

Every workflow needs error handling. Use the "Error Trigger" node to catch failed executions and send yourself an alert. A workflow that silently fails is worse than no automation at all.

■ Hardcoding credentials

Never put API keys directly in your workflow nodes. Always use the Credentials manager. This keeps your secrets secure and makes it easy to update them without editing every workflow.

■ Building too much at once

Start with the simplest version of a workflow. Get it working. Then add complexity. Trying to build a 20-node workflow on your first attempt leads to debugging nightmares.

■ Ignoring rate limits

APIs have rate limits. If your workflow runs too fast, it will hit those limits and fail. Add a "Wait" node between API calls when processing large batches of data.

■ Not testing with real data

Always test your workflow with real data before activating it. The "Execute Workflow" button lets you run it manually and inspect every node's output before going live.

Learn more about n8n and automation at aiprospace.com/tools/ai-automation-tools

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